MARIA WILLIAMS

COMPUTATIONAL NEUROSCIENCE | AI EVALUATION | FINTECH & LEGAL OPERATIONS | CREATIVE MEDIA
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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Interdisciplinary USC Computational Neuroscience candidate with experience across AI model evaluation, fintech and SBA lending, legal operations, technical support, and creative media. Skilled at translating complex systems into clear user-facing communication, evaluating model quality, coordinating client workflows, and leading content and brand initiatives with a human-centered approach.

EDUCATION

University of Southern California *Expected 2026*
B.S. in Computational Neuroscience | Minor in Dance
Focus: artificial intelligence, neuroscience, embodied cognition, brain and neuronal research, human decision-making, and human-centered design.

CORE EXPERTISE

AI model evaluation & human feedback • Generative AI & visual media • SBA lending & customer success • Legal writing & case management • Research & data interpretation • Technical troubleshooting • Content strategy & brand development • Client & partner communication

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Casca | San Francisco, CA / Remote *Dec 2024 - Present*
SBA Media Specialist / Customer Success Support
- Lead media and content strategy for an AI-native SBA loan origination platform serving banks and financial institutions.
- Create borrower-, broker-, and partner-facing communications that translate lending workflows and product capabilities into clear, actionable information.
- Previously supported SBA sales and borrower success by guiding applicants through eligibility requirements, documentation, and next steps.

Handshake AI Fellowship (Contract) | Remote *Jun 2026 - Present*
AI Trainer
- Evaluate advanced AI model outputs for reasoning, factual accuracy, instruction following, clarity, and reliability across varied tasks.
- Provide structured human feedback and high-quality data annotation to support model training, evaluation, and response improvement.
- Identify factual, logical, and task-compliance issues and document precise corrections and rationales.
- Collaborated with Frontier Labs and OpenAI on a Codex training project (October 2026).

Toloka AI *Sep 2026*
- Assisted in AI data training.

K. Williams Law Firm | Mississippi / Remote *Apr 2025 - Present*
Legal Assistant
- Support personal injury and criminal defense matters from client intake through settlement preparation and follow-up.
- Review medical records, bills, evidence, and case files while coordinating with clients, attorneys, providers, and insurance adjusters.
- Draft and revise demand letters, client updates, case summaries, and legal correspondence to support case progression and negotiations.

Ascend | Hybrid *Jun 2024 - Present*
Co-Founder & Chief Marketing Officer
- Co-founded a dance education platform connecting dancers with instructors and broadening access to high-quality training.
- Lead brand strategy, platform positioning, community outreach, content direction, and creative marketing.
- Selected for a competitive USC Marshall business incubator and placed 2nd in its pitch competition; apply neuroscience and dance knowledge to user-centered engagement strategy.

CREATIVE & TECHNICAL EXPERIENCE

Independent | Remote *Project-Based*

Freelance AI Visual Media Producer

- Partner with recording artists and other creatives to transform album covers, photography, and promotional assets into animated, AI-assisted visual content.
- Translate creative direction into motion concepts and visual variations, iterating on style, pacing, and imagery for releases and promotional rollouts.

Self-Employed | Los Angeles, CA *Aug 2025 - Present*

Freelance Model & Dancer

- Credits span fashion, commercial, music video, fragrance, lifestyle, streetwear, and background acting.
- Worked with Riot Games, GAP, Destin Conrad, fashion brands, and local artists; additional experience includes USC film/acting coursework, DJing, piano, and dance/movement direction.

USC Information Technology Services | Los Angeles, CA *Feb 2023 - Nov 2024*

IT Service Management Specialist

- Delivered frontline technical support to USC students, faculty, and staff for software, hardware, networking, and account-access issues.
- Resolved issues across Blackboard, Duo, Microsoft 365, Zoom, VPN, and multi-factor authentication; documented solutions to improve service consistency and team knowledge sharing.

ADDITIONAL EXPERIENCE

MyTutor - Tutor | Remote *Sep 2022 - Dec 2022*
Tutored high school students in math and science using explanations tailored to individual learning styles and goals.

Sellers & Associates Law Firm - Legal Intern | Jackson, MS *May 2020 - Jun 2021*
Assisted with case management, client communication, document drafting, and organization of case information.

Technology Assistant (Volunteer) - Independent | Ridgeland, MS *Jan 2022 - Mar 2022*
Collaborated on an AI-assisted communication solution using eye-tracking technology to support a teenager with severe motor restrictions.

PacSun - Sales Associate | Jackson, MS *Feb 2021 - Nov 2021*
Delivered customer service and fashion guidance while supporting sales, cashiering, inventory, and store operations.

RESEARCH, LEADERSHIP & SERVICE

- **USC Prison Education Project - Manuscript Editor & Published Author:** Edit manuscripts by incarcerated writers with a focus on clear storytelling and thoughtful revision; writing published in a USC PEP chapbook. Placed 3rd among 800+ submissions in the project's writing contest for work on justice, identity, and transformation.
- **Neuroscience x Dance Research - with Latasha Barnes:** Explore how computational neuroscience and dance intersect through embodied cognition, movement, perception, expression, and emotion, connecting movement practice with research on communication and learning.
- **USC Neurotech Club:** Participate in student-led exploration of neurotechnology, including brain-computer interfaces and neural engineering, with an emphasis on human-centered innovation.
- **Shake Dat - Media Team Member:** Support media production and digital promotion for creative nightlife and cultural events through content capture and community engagement.
- **Mayor's Youth Council:** Supported local residents through community events and food drives and completed leadership coursework taught by former UK Prime Minister Gordon Brown on global economic change strategies.

HONORS & ACHIEVEMENTS

- USC Dornsife Dean's List, Spring 2025 - earned for a 3.5+ semester GPA while completing a full letter-graded course load.
- Richard & Kathy Leventhal Scholarship - USC merit- and need-based scholarship recipient for the 2025-2026 academic year.
- BURGER KING Scholars Award - $1,000 scholarship for academic achievement, leadership, and commitment to higher education.
- National Merit Scholar - recognition for outstanding PSAT/NMSQT performance and academic achievement.
- Professional Pokemon Trading Card Game Player, 2010-2015 - achieved the #1 global ranking across all age divisions at age 10; multiple-time U.S. State Champion; qualified for and attended the Pokemon World Championships; earned prize money while developing strategic decision-making and performance under pressure.